

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Eastertide 3

Resisting with Joy ~ Humor

26 April 2026



Photo by Philippe Tarbouriech

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Meditation on HOW CAN I KEEP FROM SINGING (Improvisation)

New Organ Sounds:

Violone Bass, Bourdon, Bois Celeste, French Horn, Vox Humana, Musette, Clear Flute

Improvisation on LEANING ON THE EVERLASTING ARMS

New Organ Sounds:

Tower Bells, Chrysoglott, Cymbal Brush, Cymbal Choke, Triangle, Wood Block, Snare Drum, Bass Drum, Violone Bass, Bourdon, Bois Celeste, French Horn, Vox Humana, Clear Flute, Musette

Meditation on FINLANDIA (Improvisation)

New Organ Sounds:

French Horn, Bois Celeste, Vox Humana, Clear Flute, Violone Bass, Bourdon

Le Coucou (Louis-Claude Daquin) and Improvisation

New Organ Sounds:

Vogelgesang, Cuckoo, Clear Flute, Violone Bass, Bourdon

Poco lento in G minor from *L'Organiste* (César Franck) and Improvisation

New Organ Sounds:

Musette, Bois Celeste, French Horn, Vox Humana, Chrysoglott, Violone Bass, Bourdon, Triangle

Ave Maria (Johann Sebastian Bach/Charles Gounod, arr. C. Bull) and Improvisation

New Organ Sounds:

Chrysoglott, Bois Celeste, French Horn, Vox Humana, Violone Bass, Bourdon, Triangle, Windchimes, Cymbal Roll, Cymbal Crash, Grand Crash

Chiming of the Hour

New Organ Sound: *Tower Bells*

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Sarah Fuhrmeister & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Blessed are you when you log off the doomsroll
and choose instead to call a friend,
to check on a neighbor,
to rest your spirit from the churn,
for in your choosing, you resist despair,
and make space for love to speak.

Blessed are you when you show up
to marches, meetings, and mutual aid,

to classrooms, courtrooms, and kitchen tables,
not hardened but hopeful,
not silent but singing—
for joy will be your banner,
and courage your companion.

Blessed are you when you plant something,
in soil, in gardens and urban farms, in community,
even as the world feels uncertain,
even when the harvest is not guaranteed,
for you are practicing resurrection,
and the earth will laugh and rejoice in your care.

Blessed are you when you laugh loudly,
share a ridiculous video,
dance in your living room,
and find delight in small absurdities,
for joy is not a distraction from resistance,
it is its fuel.

Blessed are you when you tell the truth,
about injustice, about grief, about hope,
even when your voice shakes,
even when others turn away,
for your truth-telling is a seed,
and it will grow.

Blessed are you when you make art,
write poems, cook meals, sing resistance,
offer beauty in a time that tries to flatten it,
for imagination is blessed defiance,
and your creativity is sacred.

Blessed are you when you rest,
when you refuse the lie
that your worth is measured by exhaustion,
when you honor your body,
your limits, your need,
for rest, too, is resistance.

Blessed are you when you keep loving,
through disappointment, difference and indifference,
through the long work of justice,
for love that persists
is the deepest joy we can know.

*Blessed are we
when we resist with joy—
when we choose life, again and again,
and trust that even now,*

*even here,
something sacred is unfolding.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

My Life Flows On

ENDLESS SONG

My life flows on in endless song; above earth's lamentation,
I hear the sweet, though far off hymn that hails a new creation.
Through all the tumult and the strife, I hear the music ringing:
It finds an echo in my soul, how can I keep from singing?

What though my joys and comforts die? My Savior still is living.
What though the shadows gather 'round? A new song Christ is giving.
No storm can shake my inmost calm, while to that Rock I'm clinging:
Since love commands both heaven and earth, how can I keep from singing?

I lift my eyes; the cloud grows thin; I see the blue above it;
And day by day this pathway smooths, since first I learned to love it.
The peace of Christ makes fresh my heart, a fountain ever springing:
All things are mine since I am Christ's, how can I keep from singing?

Prayer of Awareness

Rev. Lehman

Spirit of the Living God,
open our senses to your creation:
a fiery sunset on a wide horizon
a spider's delicate web, spangled with dew,
the vibrancy of a child's painting,
the miniature world of life in a rock pool...
You are the joy in the small things of everyday.

God, open our senses as we remember:
A mockingbird's song,
children's laughter in the playground,
music of the city street and traffic's hum,
the joy of a choir singing...
You are the joy in the small things of everyday.

God, help us savor:
A meal prepared with love for us by another person,
the tang of an exotic fruit,
the morning's first cup of coffee or tea,
an ice cream at the beach or from the freezer...
You are the joy in the small things of every day.

God, help us to feel:
The sun on our face,
a kind word when we are sad or fearful,

the softness of a beloved pet's fur,
the smoothness of a river pebble
from last year's vacation...

*Help us to remember,
you are the joy in the small things
that we sense on this day -
and in all the days to come.
Amen.*

[adapt/Philip Garside NZ]

***Introit**

"I love to laugh"
Cathedral Choir

SWEET HONEY IN THE ROCK

***The Lord's Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.
Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.
Amen and Amen!*

John Philip Newell

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

This morning and in all the mornings to come,
may the peace and joy of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

Sarah Fuhrmeister & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

from the Gospel of Luke, chapter 24

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace...
Thanks be to God!

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Loving and Laughter-Filled God...

I laughed and I could move through my arthritis,
I laughed and decreased my stress.
I laughed and my mind became clearer.
I laughed and relaxed in chemo or dialysis.
I laughed and felt control over my chronic pain.
I laughed and boosted my immune system.

I laughed and somebody believed me
when I said my faith was full of joy.
I laughed and I had the energy for one more
letter, email, organizational meeting for justice.
I laughed and it was easier to be generous
with my money and my time.

I listened to someone else's laughter
and my grief eased just a little.
I saw the humor in a squirrel's antics,
my hat-hair, and running to put out
the trash in my pajamas,
and my next choice of words were kind ones.

I said, "I'm not comfortable with that,"
at an ugly joke about someone different,
and my spirit became peaceful.

I laughed and my wrinkles turned up.
I laughed and my neck and shoulders relaxed.

And I prayed to laugh when I didn't feel like laughing.
I laughed and I knew it was a prayer.
This morning, may it be so.
May it be so for all of us, O God.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Laughing Meditation"
Cathedral Choir

DAVID HARRIS

The laughing meditation is a practice during which everyone (all of us) in the room laugh together for several minutes. The piece "Laughing Meditation" provides a prelude to that practice. You are all invited to laugh if moved, and to join the choir in sustained laughter at the conclusion of the music.

Sermon

Humility ~ Laughter is Food for Our Souls

Rev. Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Prayer of Blessing

God of fresh bread and newly harvested fruit of the vine,
we sense your presentness among us
in grace-filled moments of sharing,
in carefully created communities of loving solidarity,
in holy times of birthing new life
from the renewing of our minds.

*We delight in the moving of your steadfast Spirit
that calls us to find water for the thirsty,
invites us to prepare meals
for all who hunger, and
give us the gifts to welcome all in our midst.*

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Sarah Fuhrmeister

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

*"The Nutcracker and Sugartongs" from Sense/Nonsense
Laude*

DAVID HARRIS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister & Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Holy One,
as the Risen One broke
into conversation on the road to Emmaus,
we ask that our discourse of daily worries
might be changed by the conversation of joy
we have all experienced in this sacred place today.

*In the mystery of you, O God,
we have been warmed
by each other's presence,
from near and far.*

Help us now to recognize your presence
throughout all our lives,
as we are assured once again,
you are never finished with us:
in the Christ we are ever emerging,
through the life, death, and life from death
we have been shown, in Jesus the Christ.

*In the days to come,
let us find a faithful resonance
with your gracious, intimate presence,
which causes our hearts to burn with the hope
that the best is yet to come.* [unitedchurchofcanda]
May it ever be so.
*May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Know that you are loved by a God of surprises and miracles,
a God who meets us unexpectedly as the stranger,
and who delights with a wicked sense of humor.

This same God walks with us in uncertain times,
giving us strength and bringing us the love of this community.

May it ever be so.
*May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

Choral Response

**"Emoji Choir Challenge 1"
Cathedral Choir**

LAUREL IRENE AND DAVID HARRIS

***Hymn for the Journey**

Leaning on the Everlasting Arms

What a fellowship, what a joy divine,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!
What a blessedness, what a peace is mine,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!

Refrain: Leaning, leaning,
Safe and secure from all alarms;
Leaning, leaning,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms.

O how sweet to walk in this pilgrim way,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!
O how bright the path grows from day to day,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!
Refrain

What have I to dread, what have I to fear,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!
I have peace complete with my Lord so near,
Leaning on the Everlasting Arms!
Refrain

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Le Coucou - Reprise (Louis-Claude Daquin)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"Humor and music share the core tenet of timing. This is a reality that Haydn discovered in his famous joke symphony, as but one example. The challenge with humor and music coexisting rests in the nature of timing in each. Because of music's persistent soundscape, jokes struggle to land. Humor in music, therefore, takes on a form more akin to a sitcom than a standup. There are rare moments to laugh out loud, and more a consistent presence of quiet giggles. I listened back to all of the humor-driven musicians that I respect from the past several decades, and their music felt too specific to their time and place, and strained to fit into our space this week. I decided to program pieces that I've written for us or groups like ours to hopefully spark some alignment and inspire a few giggles. The "Laughing Meditation" today was inspired by Laughter Yoga, which started in the 1990s in India. In Laughter Yoga groups of people gather to laugh simply because they can. According to one article: "Practitioners choose to laugh for their health. Laughter Yoga is performed without any humorous reason to laugh, with one practitioner observing that 'the body does not know that we're faking it.' My "Laughing Meditation" uses music and silliness to get us into the laughing space, and then asks everyone in the room to join us in sustained laughter. We first sang and laughed it during quarantine, and I'm excited to experience it in a live setting with you all. I wrote "Sense/Nonsense" for C3LA to a set of Edward Leary poems I read by accident one night. I love how Leary uses sideways characters derived from everyday life dropped into odd circumstances to remind us how precious life is. In the third movement of my piece, a nutcracker and a sugartongs get a wild hair and decide that life as it was handed to them isn't enough. A particularly delightful line happens at the end of the first stanza when they ruminate that everyone else "never seems happy unless he is riding a horse." As simpleminded as it seems, the two set out on a grand adventure to do just that. They stir up everyone in the house. Some are shocked, others surprised, and everyone gets caught up in the excitement. In the end, after all the silliness, they discover that the mundane nature of their previous existence never reflected who they were, and celebrate a new

hope. I love Leary's characters including the mice, the mustard pot, and the ladle and how they all clamour about. For the music I created a folk-like melody and ladled on a heaping of character voice moments to bring those individuals to life. The silliness is the humor. The goal is to help us feel full of joy as we discover this new world and chuckle at their exploits. Ysaye Barnwell's "I Love To Laugh" takes a similarly simple sentiment and gives it a similarly folk-like feel in order to evoke those same chuckle-inducing vibes. And mine and Laurel's "Emoji Choir Challenge" is built of several movements all marked by emojis. In each the choir has some decisions to make about how the emojis determine what sounds they'll make. We'll only do the first this week, and added an homage to Monty Python for fun. Laughter is certainly divine. It fills us with the promise of the moment, and brings us closer together. I hope that our silliness this week helps you find some fullness, and that you'll choose to laugh with us."

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